

UNIT 2 · LESSON 6

Rewriting the Script

40–45 min · December Week 2

★ ★ HIGHEST RISK

OBJECTIVE	Students examine the scripts they have inherited about their worth, capacity, and belonging — and practice the Compassionate Witness as a tool for rewriting scripts that are not serving them.
CASE FOCUS	Self-Awareness: examining inherited self-narratives · Self-Management: building the Compassionate Witness as a sustained practice
SCENARIO CARDS	None — all work is private and worksheet-guided
QUICK REVIEW	Skip Quick Review. Begin with the OPENING RITUAL — 2 full minutes of grounding before any content.

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 6–8 · MIDDLE / JUNIOR HIGH

Goal 1 — Self-Awareness & Self-Management**1A.3a** Analyze factors that create stress or that motivate successful performance.**1B.3a** Analyze how personal qualities influence choices and successes.*Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).*

★ ★ MANDATORY PRE-LESSON REQUIREMENTS

All must be met before class begins.

- ☐ School counselor is physically present in the room for the full lesson — NOT on-call, NOT in the hallway
- ☐ Crisis resources posted VISIBLY: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline · Crisis Text Line: text HOME to 741741
- ☐ Lesson NOT scheduled before a holiday, weekend, break, or fire-drill day
- ☐ No substitute teacher present — only the delivering teacher
- ☐ You have briefed the counselor on students who showed concerning patterns in L1–L5
- ☐ You have taken 60 seconds to settle yourself before students arrive — your regulated presence is the room's most important safety tool

COUNSELOR CO-FACILITATION ROLE

Sit in a position where you can observe all students without being the centre of attention. Primary job: notice — students who stop writing, leave the room, or show visible distress.

If a student leaves the room: COUNSELOR FOLLOWS. Teacher stays with the class.

After class: mandatory same-day debrief with the teacher — regardless of whether a disclosure occurred.

OPENING · OPENING RITUAL · 4-5 MINUTES · DO NOT
SHORTEN

"We all carry scripts — inherited ideas about our worth, our capacity, and whether we belong. Some of these scripts were written by people who loved us. Some were written by people who hurt us. Most were written before we were old enough to question them. Today we look at the scripts — and ask which ones we want to keep."

Pause after this opening. Allow 30 seconds of silence. The counselor holds the room with you.

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · Steps 1 — 3 · read aloud or in your own words

01 What Scripts Are

6 MIN

"A script is a narrative we carry about ourselves that we treat as true without examining it. 'I am not smart enough.' 'I do not belong here.' 'I always mess things up.' Scripts often originated in specific experiences or relationships — but they generalise. They spread from one context to everything."

Write these three example scripts on the board. *"Notice: none of these scripts have your name on them. But many of you know exactly what your script says."*

WORKSHEET**Script Analysis Worksheet**

U2·L6 · Private Primary Activity · ★★

Highest Risk Lesson

Critical: Students work ONLY from the worksheet structure. Five sections: (1) A script I carry. (2) Where it came from. (3) Evidence that contradicts it. (4) What it costs me to keep it. (5) A more accurate, fair version. **Never collected. Never shared with anyone including the teacher.**

02 Script Analysis · Primary Activity

18 MIN

"The worksheet in front of you has five sections. Work through each one, in order, privately. I will not be reading what you write. The counselor will not be reading what you write. This belongs to you."

Students work completely independently. No pairs. No sharing. Teacher steps back from the centre of the room.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who stops writing after section 2 (where the script came from) and stares or puts their head down.

MAY SIGNAL Identifying the origin of a script — a person, an experience, a system — can be more activating than naming the script itself. The origin may involve abuse, trauma, or systemic harm.

ACTION Counselor approaches quietly. Teacher remains with the class. Counselor: "You don't have to write more than you have. Section 5 is the most important — write a word, any word, that is fairer." Follow your disclosure protocol if the student speaks.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who leaves the room during the Script Analysis.

MAY SIGNAL This is the highest-disclosure-risk lesson of Semester 1. Leaving during the private writing portion is a significant signal.

ACTION **Counselor follows immediately.** Teacher stays with class. Say to class: "Keep working." Do not draw attention. Counselor follows established protocol.

03 Rewriting with the Compassionate Witness

8 MIN

"The Compassionate Witness does not deny the pain that wrote the script. It does not pretend the experience did not happen. It asks: Is this script still serving me? What would a more accurate, fair script say?"

Students write an alternative script in one sentence. *"It does not have to feel true yet. Writing it is the beginning of making space for it."*

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who tears up or covers their worksheet, or who appears very still and withdrawn during Step 3.

MAY SIGNAL The alternative script — the more accurate, fair version — may be the first time

this student has ever considered that their inherited script might not be true. That realisation can be destabilising before it is liberating.

ACTION Do not retrieve. Do not approach to console — this can amplify. Hold the room. Counselor monitors. After class: mandatory debrief protocol.

TEACHING TIP

What to say (post these on your desk during this lesson):

"You do not have to share anything. This is entirely private."

"One sentence is enough. You do not have to explain where it came from."

"The Compassionate Witness does not have to feel true yet. Writing it is the beginning."

What NOT to say: "Can you tell me more about where that script came from?" · Do not probe.

"Share what you wrote with your partner." · Never for this lesson. "Who wrote that script for you?" · Do not probe origins.

EXIT TICKET

"A script I carry that is not serving me is _____. A more accurate, fair version is _____." · Allow 4 full minutes. Do not rush the close.

Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

After Class — Mandatory Same-Day Debrief.

Teacher and counselor debrief the same day. Discuss: any students who left the room, any visible distress, any content shared voluntarily. Counselor follows up individually with flagged students before Unit 3 begins. Teacher writes a private note of any significant observations — not in a gradebook, not in a shared system. Teacher uses their own restorative practice tonight. This lesson costs something. That is it working.

TEACHER REFLECTION

This is the highest-disclosure-risk lesson of the first semester. Your regulated nervous system is the room's most important safety tool. After this lesson: brief your counselor — for your own state, not just for student disclosures.

See [Section 4](#) — Teacher Wellbeing for the full protocol for what this lesson commonly produces for delivering teachers.

FAMILY CONNECTION

A Note Home

Today was one of the most significant lessons of the year. The school counselor co-facilitated. Your child examined scripts they carry about themselves — inherited ideas about their worth and belonging.

If they seem reflective or heavy this evening, that is healthy. If they seem distressed, please contact the counselor directly.

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

★★ **Highest risk lesson.** Counselor co-facilitation required. Safe messaging guidelines apply throughout. Do not schedule before any break. Do not allow a substitute teacher. Crisis resources must be visibly posted.

Mandatory same-day counselor debrief regardless of whether disclosure occurred.

ANCHOR CHART · NO NEW ANCHOR CHART — CRISIS
RESOURCES VISIBLY POSTED**Build Specification**

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line — Text HOME to 741741

Your school counselor — Name: _____ Contact: _____

Post at student eye level. Visible from every seat. No other new visual for this lesson.

P O S T : Before U2L6. Counselor physically in room first. · **K E E P :** ☹ Permanent — rest of the year.

UNIT 2 · LESSON 6 · WORKSHEET

Rewriting the Script

A script is a story we treat as true without ever examining it.

PRIVATE WORK

Completely private · The teacher and counselor will not read this · It belongs to you

1

The script I carry

A sentence I sometimes believe about myself is...

2

Where it was written

This script may have first come from... (a person, a moment, an experience)

3

Is it the whole truth?

Evidence that this script is NOT the full story of who I am...

4

The Compassionate Witness

What would someone who saw the whole of me — with kindness — say about this script?

5

Rewriting the script

An alternative script, in one sentence. It does not have to feel true yet.

IF YOU NEED SUPPORT — RIGHT NOW OR LATER

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — call or text 988

Crisis Text Line — text HOME to 741741

Your school counselor — Name: _____ Contact: _____

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Sample Lesson · Book 3 · The Interior (6–8)

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